

Removal Requests

About this report

Insights into legal demands to remove content from Twitter, and other requests to remove content based on local law(s) from around the world.

Legal Demands

Published on July 28, 2022

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01. Latest Data: Legal Demands

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02. Overview

This section covers the latest data about third-party legal demands that compel X to remove content under our [Country Withheld Content](#) ("CWC") policy.

There are also details about the latest trends in global volumes of requests, accounts specified, and the total compliance rate. The total compliance rate is a simplified metric that combines all of X's removal actions—accounts withheld, posts withheld, and accounts TOS.

Some notable changes since the last report:

Legal demands

+10%

Compliance rate

-5%

Increase in **global legal demands** compared to the last reporting period.

Decrease in **global compliance rate** compared to the last reporting period.

Accounts specified

+1%

Increase in **global accounts specified** compared to the last reporting period.

Accounts withheld

-86%

Decrease in **global accounts withheld** compared to the last reporting period.

Posts withheld

+14%

Increase in **global posts withheld** compared to the last reporting period.

Accounts TOS

+58%

Increase in **global accounts TOS** compared to the last reporting period.



03. Analysis

Big picture

X received 47,572 legal demands to remove content specifying 198,931 accounts. This record-breaking number of accounts specified for content removal is now the largest ever that X has received since our first transparency report. The 10% increase in the total number of legal demands in this reporting period is another record-breaking number that makes this transparency report historically significant. It is noteworthy that during this time, X observed an increase of reports containing a substantial number of reported accounts (“batch reports”). Notably, we received batch reports from [South Korea](#) and the [United Arab Emirates](#).

The South Korean government reported 966% more accounts compared to the previous transparency report. This number was influenced by seven batch reports submitted by Korean government agencies, who reported content alleged to be illegal under Article 44-7 of the Act on Promotion of Information and Communications Network Utilization and Information Protection. In total, X actioned 43,366 accounts for violations of the [Platform manipulation and spam policy](#), [Illegal or certain regulated goods or services](#), and [Child sexual exploitation](#) policies.

Along with South Korea, the United Arab Emirates submitted their first batch reports during this reporting period. The Telecommunications and Digital Government Regulatory Authority submitted 12 separate batch reports totaling 2,851 accounts citing crimes related to illegal sexual services. Many of these accounts were already suspended due to previous actions, however, X actioned 2,335 accounts in total, which were in violation mostly of the [Platform manipulation and spam policy](#) and [Illegal or certain regulated goods or services](#) policies.

Overall, X withheld or otherwise removed some or all of the reported content in response to 51% of global legal demands, down 5% from the previous reporting period.

Country insights

This record number of [legal demands](#) originated from 44 different countries during this reporting period, and included the first legal demand received from [Ghana](#). X has received legal demands from 95 different countries since we published our first transparency report.

Top requesters

97% of the total global volume of legal demands originated from only five countries (in decreasing order): [Japan](#), [Russia](#), [South Korea](#), [Turkey](#), and [India](#). These five countries have remained X's top requesting countries for legal demands over the past three years.

Japan continues to submit the highest volume of requests, and was responsible for half of all global legal demands received in this period. 96% of requests from Japan referred to laws regarding the prohibition of financial crimes, narcotics, and prostitution. Russia submitted the second highest number of legal demands to X, accounting for 18% of all global legal demands. However, Russian requests decreased compared to the noticeable spike in the last transparency report. Content involving self-harm and suicide consisted of 70% of all Russian requests and has remained the primary issue-type reported by the Russian government. This is followed with 14% of Russian requests reporting child sexual exploitation and explicit media against minors. South Korea jumped to become the third largest requestor of legal demands, accounting for 12% of the global volume. In this reporting period, the South Korean government submitted their highest number of content removal requests ever. Turkey follows as the fourth largest requestor, accounting for 9% of global legal demands. India is the fifth highest requestor, accounting for 8% of global legal demands.



Japan

Japan maintains its spot as the top requester of legal demands to X. The volume of Japanese **legal demands increased by 27%**, coinciding with a **30% increase of accounts specified**.



Russia

Russia kept its position as X's second largest requester of legal demands, accounting for **18% of the global volume**. Russia decreased the legal demands submissions by 20%, but it still remained the second highest requester. There was also a decrease of 35% in the number of accounts specified by the Russian government compared to the previous reporting period.



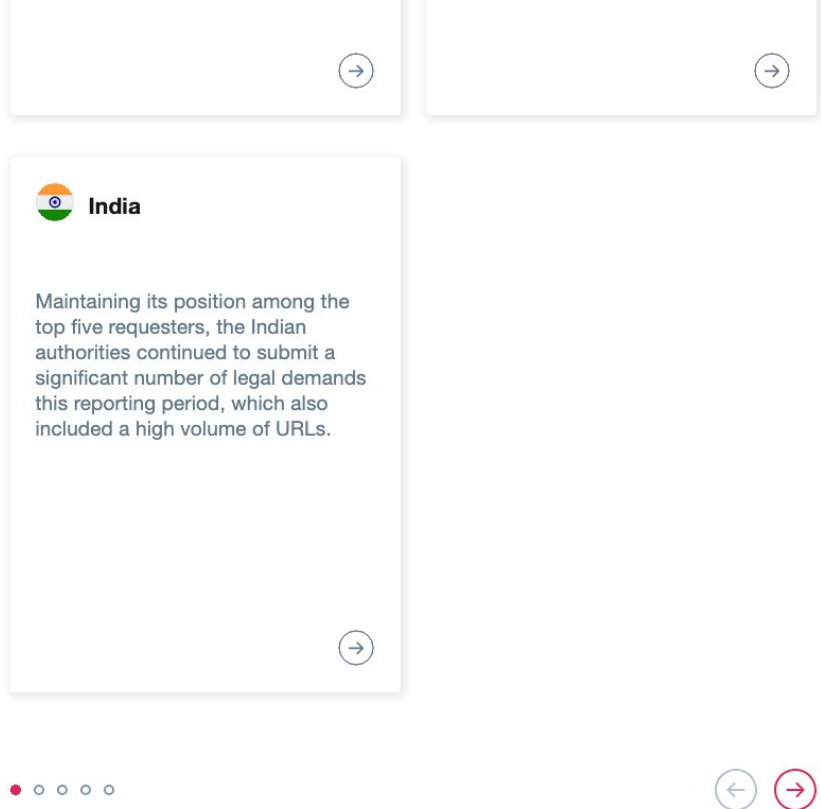
South Korea

South Korea moved up to become X's third largest requester of legal demands. The South Korean government **increased their legal demands by 174%** compared to the previous reporting period. The accounts specified in these South Korean requests account for 47% of all accounts specified globally.



Turkey

Turkey dropped to X's fourth largest requester. This is due to the Turkish government submitting **21% fewer legal demands**. Despite this decrease, Turkey actually increased the number of **accounts specified in their requests by 24%**. This increase totaled 8,496 accounts, which is Turkey's highest number of accounts reported since 2019.



Verified journalists and news outlets

349 accounts of verified journalists and news outlets located around the world were subject to 326 legal demands, a 103% increase in the number of accounts since the previous reporting period and also the largest number of accounts specified by foreign and domestic governments that belong to verified journalists and news outlets we've ever seen. This spike is largely attributed to legal demands submitted by [India](#) (114), [Turkey](#) (78), [Russia](#) (55), and [Pakistan](#) (48). X also saw reports on verified journalists and news outlets from other jurisdictions, such as [Brazil](#) (8), [Qatar](#) (4), [France](#) (3), [Israel](#) (3), [Mexico](#) (3), [Germany](#) (2), [South Korea](#) (2), [Thailand](#) (2), [Colombia](#) (1), [Indonesia](#) (1), [Serbia](#) (1), and the [United States](#) (1).

There was a steady increase in actions taken on verified journalists and news outlets. In total, 17 posts from verified journalists and news outlets were withheld in this reporting period compared to 11 posts withheld during the previous transparency report period.

Other Requests

X received its first Targeted Correction Direction (TCD) from the Singaporean government, citing the Protection from Online Falsehoods and Manipulation Act (POFMA). A correction direction was issued on the basis that the post misquoted a government official's speech out of context. A correction label, along with the correction post provided to X by the Singaporean government, was issued to all X users that engaged with the reported post. For more information regarding this request, see [here](#).

04. Withheld Content

This data includes all legal demands where we employed our [Country Withheld Content](#) ("CWC") tool during this period, resulting in either posts or accounts being withheld. Where permitted, X provided notice to identified account holders and published copies of the underlying legal demands that resulted in withheld content to [Lumen](#) for public review.²⁴

We have now used CWC in 24 countries in response to legal demands: [Argentina](#), [Australia](#), [Brazil](#), [Canada](#), [Finland](#), [France](#), [Germany](#), [India](#), [Indonesia](#), [Ireland](#), [Israel](#), [Italy](#), [Japan](#), [Netherlands](#), [New Zealand](#), [Pakistan](#), [Russia](#), [Singapore](#), [South Korea](#), [Spain](#), [Turkey](#), and the [United Kingdom](#). During this reporting period, X withheld content in [Taiwan](#) and the [United Arab Emirates](#) for the first time.

In total, X withheld content at the account or post level in 13 of those 24 countries during this period.

during this period.

Examples (Lumen links to corresponding legal demands available below):

**Brazil**

X received a court order from Rio de Janeiro's 30th Lower Civil Court for the removal of 18 posts that publicized sexual misconduct allegations against a leading national figure in the Brazilian music industry, along with public figures within a political family in Brazil. Five posts were deleted by the users, however the remaining **13 posts were withheld** in Brazil in accordance with the court order under Article 19 of the Marco Civil Law of the Internet.

[→](#)

**Germany**

X received two legal demands from the legal representatives of a public figure involved in alleged domestic abuse crimes. X **withheld 11 posts** in Germany in accordance with a court order from Landesgericht Berlin on the basis of prohibited information sharing.

[→](#)

**India**

X received a legal demand from the National Commission for Protection of Child Rights to remove content relating to privacy issues involving a minor. The reported post published by a high-ranking political figure was withheld in India in compliance with Indian law.

[→](#)

**South Korea**

X received a legal demand from the Korea Communications Commission regarding content that violated laws against harmful media towards minors. X suspended 55 accounts for violating X's Platform manipulation and spam policy and **withheld 72 posts** in South Korea in compliance with the Act on Promotion of Information and Communication Network Utilization and Information Protection.

[→](#)

**Taiwan**

X received two legal demands from Taiwan's Criminal Investigation Bureau reporting the promotion and distribution of illegal drugs occurring on the platform. X **withheld two accounts** in Taiwan in accordance with Taiwan's Narcotics Hazard Prevention Act and the Code of Criminal Procedure. This is X's first withholding in Taiwan.

[→](#)

**United Arab Emirates**

X received a legal demand from the Telecommunication Regulatory Authority to remove one account selling and trading narcotic, psychotropic substances, and other drug-related products on the platform. In accordance with Article 36 of the Federal Decree-Law no. (5) of 2012 on Combating Cybercrimes of the UAE, X **withheld the account** in the UAE which was X's first withholding in this country.

[→](#)

[←](#)[→](#)

05. Restored Content

Content is typically restored to X after a successful appeal of an original court order or because a legal procedure expired. Restored content, previously referred to as “un-withheld content”, may pertain to accounts or posts that were withheld prior to this

current reporting period.

Examples (Lumen links to corresponding legal demands available below¹):

 **Turkey**

X initially **withheld two accounts** in Turkey in accordance with a court order made under Turkish law, Number 5651 of Article 8/A, for alleged terrorist content. The **accounts were later restored** after Turkish courts accepted X's objection to the removal on the basis of freedom of expression.

→

06.

TOS Violations and Labeling

This section includes instances where, in response to legal demands identifying the specified accounts or posts, content was removed from X after determining it violated X's TOS.² We review all reported content for violations of X's TOS before assessing it further independent of any underlying claims.

We take an objective approach to reviewing legal demands for possible violations of X's TOS. The fact that the reporters in these cases may be involved in litigation, or may be government / law enforcement officials, had no bearing on whether any action was taken under X's TOS. This approach is consistent with our commitment to [free expression](#).

Examples:

 **Canada**

X **received a legal demand** from the Office of the Commissioner of Canada Elections. One post was reported for distributing false information on special ballots relating to the 2021 General Election. The **post was removed** under X's Civic integrity policy.

→

 **France**

X **received legal demands** from France's National Police to remove content that leaked a COVID-19 sanitary pass belonging to a French political and public figure. One **post was removed** under X's Private information and media policy and one account was actioned under X's Counterfeit policy.

→

 **Ghana**

X **received two legal demands** from Ghana Police Service, which marked Ghana's first request for content removal. One account and 10 posts were reported for disseminating false

 **Malaysia**

X **received a legal demand** from the Malaysian Communication and Multimedia Commission, due to a complaint received from Malaysia's Ministry of Housing and Local Government reporting that a X user was publishing purposely-misleading

information and spreading hate speech against a national political party. The reported **account was suspended** for violating X's Non-consensual nudity policy.



information to deceive Malaysian users through financial transactions. The **reported account was suspended** for violating X's Financial scam policy.



Nepal

X **received a legal demand** from the Nepal Police reporting one account impersonating a Nepali politician and publishing unverified statements regarding other high ranking political figures. X **took action** on the account for violating X's Impersonation policy.



Qatar

X **received a legal demand** from the Ministry of Interior to remove a post that distributed fake government documents. The post was removed and the **account was suspended** under X's Platform manipulation and spam policy.



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07.

Majority no action

This section includes instances where, in response to a **legal demand**, no action was taken on the majority of the reported content, as most **accounts / posts** were determined not to violate X's TOS or to merit withholding under CWC. Generally, we do not take action on newsworthy content or political speech protected under [UN-recognized principles](#) of free expression consistent with [X values](#).

Examples:

Colombia

X received a court order from Bogota's Twelfth Municipal Court on Small Laboral Claims for the removal of one account. Content from this reported user was claimed to be involved in crimes against the government, specifically for publishing materials regarding the mishandling of Covid-19 government operations in Colombia. **No action was taken** on the posts, whose account belonged to a leading international journalist in the fields of compliance and anti-corruption. The posts also did not violate Our Rules and TOS and the materials shared were newsworthy.



Thailand

X **received a legal demand** from the Ministry of Digital Economy and Society for the removal of 12 posts. We sought additional information from the requester, pending which **no violations to Our Rules and TOS were found**.



Turkey

X received a court order requesting the removal of 21 posts allegedly violating the personal rights of a high ranking political figure under

high-ranking political figure under Article 9 of Turkish Law 5651. No violations to Our Rules and TOS were found, and the posts shared newsworthy content. As such, **no actions** were taken on all reported posts



Local Law(s)

Published on July 28, 2022

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01. Latest Data: Local Law(s)

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Removal Requests

02. Overview

This section includes reports based on local law(s) from trusted reporters and non-governmental organizations ("NGOs") identified by the European Commission.

There are also details about the latest trends in global volumes of requests, accounts specified, total compliance rate, accounts withheld, posts withheld, and accounts TOS.

Some notable changes since the last report:

Reports

-45%

Compliance rate

-11%

Decrease in **global reports based on local law(s)** compared to the last reporting period.

Decrease in **the global compliance rate** compared to the last reporting period.

Accounts specified

-49%

Decrease in **global accounts specified** compared to the last reporting period.

Accounts withheld

-100%

Decrease in **global accounts withheld** compared to the last reporting period. Accounts withheld decreased from 1 to 0.

Posts withheld

-14%

Decrease in **global posts withheld** compared to the last reporting period.

Accounts TOS

-53%

Decrease in **global accounts TOS** compared to the last reporting period.



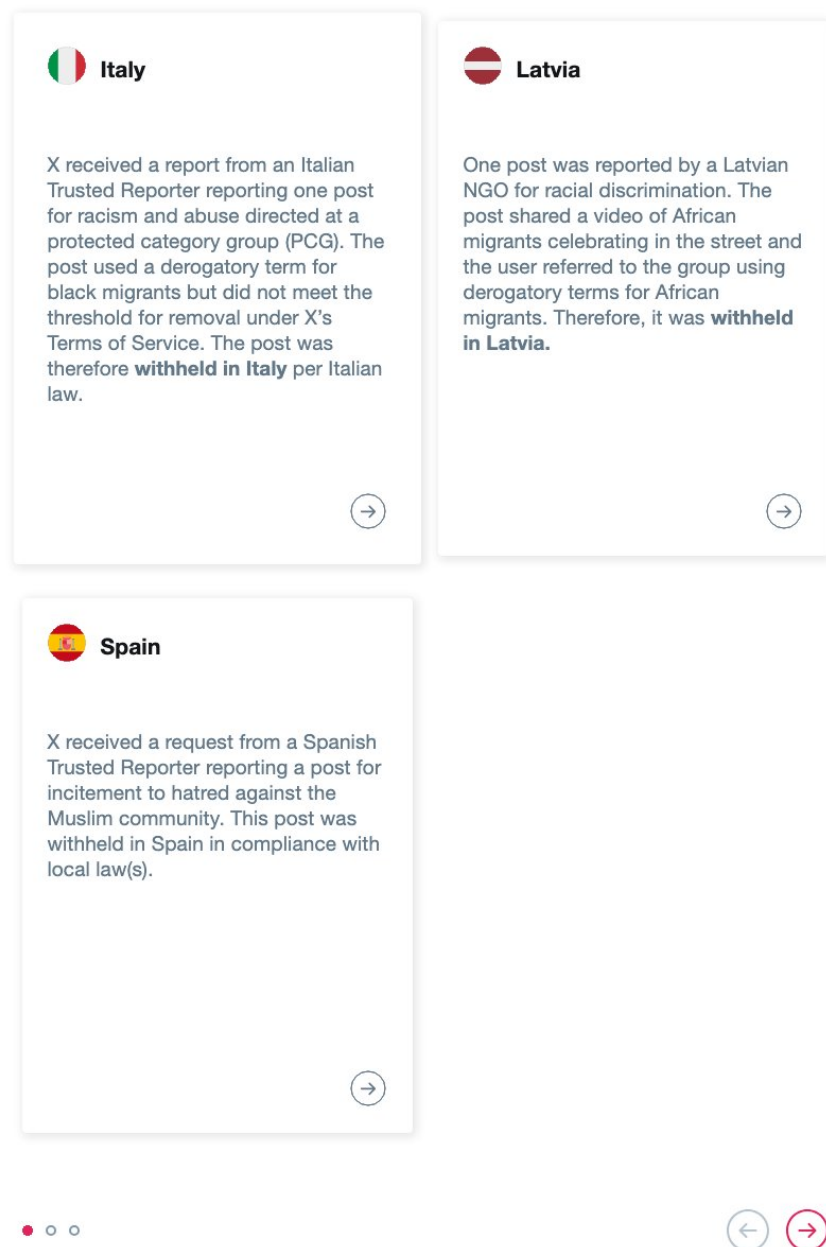
03. Analysis

All reported content is first reviewed for potential violations of [X's TOS](#). Any content that is found to be violating is removed from the platform. Content that does not violate X's TOS is then reviewed for potential withholding based on the local law(s) of the reporting jurisdiction.

Trusted reporters and NGOs

In April 2017, X allowlisted the first group of EU organizations as part of our continuing efforts under the EU [Code of Conduct on Countering Hate Speech Online](#). Since then, several more organizations have joined the program. Broadly speaking, the organizations that submitted reports under the Code of Conduct work on protecting and furthering human rights, and preventing issues such as racism, xenophobia, or homophobia. X has formed partnerships with trusted reporters and NGOs from [Belgium](#), [France](#), [Germany](#), the [Netherlands](#), [Spain](#), [Italy](#), [Latvia](#), [Austria](#), [Estonia](#), [Czech Republic](#), [Ireland](#), [Poland](#), [Sweden](#), [Croatia](#) and [Greece](#) to date.

X received 45% fewer reports based on local law(s) from trusted reporters and NGOs, impacting approximately 49% fewer accounts during this reporting period.



04. German Network Enforcement Act

The Network Enforcement Act (Netzwerkdurchsetzungsgesetz, aka NEA) is a German law that came into effect on January 1, 2018.

X is required to publish a biannual report in German regarding our handling of complaints submitted from users or complaints bodies pursuant to the law. The most recent [report](#) was published in January 2022, covering the reporting period of July 1 to December 31, 2021, and is available to download from the [Germany country report](#).

Footnotes

Some cases received during this reporting period may be in progress and may not be closed at the time of reporting.

Each request may identify multiple items to be removed. For example, a single request may ask us to remove individual posts, an entire account, or both.

We may not comply with every request or all aspects of a request for a variety of reasons. For example, we do not comply with requests that fail to identify content on X.

Legal Demands

¹ This section does not include reports submitted by government officials to review content solely under X's TOS. More information about Our Rules enforcement is available [here](#).

² Withheld Content corresponding legal demands Lumen links:

[2.](#) Court orders are often accompanied by a non-disclosure order that prevents X for notifying a specified account holder.

Where permitted, X has published copies of removal requests to [Lumen](#), at times redacted, that have resulted in content being withheld. We try to redact as little information as possible. Redacted information usually consists of personally identifiable information, but may also include defamatory statements or information that we are prohibited from publishing.

- [Brazil](#)

- [Germany](#)

- [India](#)

- [South Korea](#)

- [Taiwan](#)

- [United Arab Emirates](#)

[4.](#) Restored Content corresponding legal demands Lumen links:

- [Turkey 1](#)

- [Turkey 2](#)

[5.](#) "X's TOS" is made up of X's [Terms of Service](#) and the [Our Rules](#). More information about Our Rules enforcement is available [here](#).

Local Law(s)

[6.](#) Trusted reporters/NGOs corresponding removal requests Lumen links:

- [Latvia](#)

- [Spain](#)

- [Italy](#)

Other reports



Information Requests

Legal requests for account information



Rules Enforcement

Our Rules and TOS enforcement



Moderation Research

Disclosures and elections integrity



